

weather events over recent years. The establishment of digital agriculture infrastructure, including an annual digital crop survey, will also improve credit risk assessment and could increase formal credit penetration in the sector.

PREPARING THE NEXT GENERATION

A notable aspect of this Budget is the focus on job creation and skilling for the youth, who are emerging as the new consumer class. By outlining funds and policies such as the employment-linked incentive scheme, encouraging internship programmes, and skilling initiatives, this Budget has focussed on future-proofing the growth engines for the next generation. From the FMCG perspective, these measures will ensure higher levels of disposable incomes for a longer period.

FOCUS ON INFRA

Infrastructure development is crucial for India's economic progress and global competitiveness. One of the most significant announcements of this Budget has been the allocation of 3.4% of India's GDP towards the growth of infrastructure—all with the focus of making the country a global manufacturing hub. These measures will enhance supply chain efficiency, facilitating wider distribution networks.

With its focus on urban and rural infrastructure development, the government is signalling its focus on strengthening India's road, water, and air transport mecha-

nisms, making the movement of goods much easier. Particularly, the transit-oriented development plans for 14 large cities, with a population above 3 million, as well as the proposals for more industrial parks, the government is not only creating jobs but also improving connectivity for transportation across India.

Further, the launch of Phase IV of the Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana will provide all-weather

Budget has directly and indirectly proposed policies to boost consumption by increasing the levels of disposable income. The revision of the tax slabs and increase in the standard deduction to ₹75,000 is likely to enhance purchasing power among the salaried and middle classes.

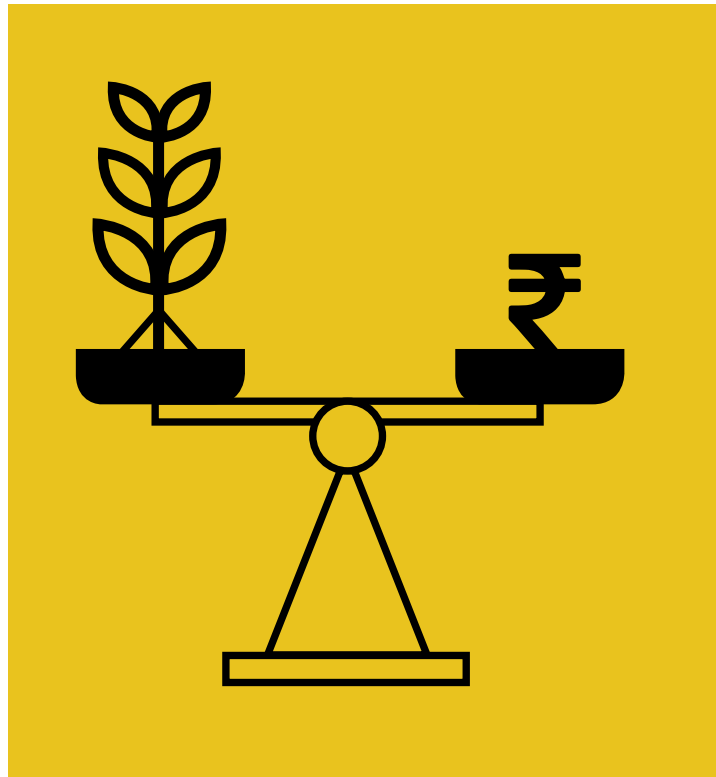
Households will have more discretionary spending, resulting in more products in their shop-

ping carts. The allocation of funds for rural development will spur rural demand, indirectly boosting consumption in non-metro markets. With the PM Surya Ghar Muft Bijli Yojana, which proposes to enable 10 million households to obtain free electricity up to 300 units every month with solar panels, the government is enhancing consumers' spending ability, thus circulating money back into the economy.

If executed well, the nine-point agenda laid out by the government will address key concerns. The proposed initiatives need to be monitored throughout to ensure a positive and long-term impact on the sectors and the economy at large. **BT**

The writer is MD and CEO, Marico Ltd. Views are personal

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connectivity to 25,000 rural habitations. Moreover, investments in digital infrastructure are poised to strengthen India's digital economy, supporting e-commerce, and digital governance initiatives.

A LONGER SHOPPING LIST

Reviving consumer demand has been given visible emphasis. This